Maihan Abdullah

MD · MPH · Public Health Researcher · Cancer Control & Health Policy

Annandale, VA, U.S.A. | +1-909-905-7007 | maihanabdullah22@gmail.com | LinkedIn

PROFILE

Public health researcher and physician with experience spanning cancer prevention and control, population-based research, health systems, policy development, national program leadership, international public health, and capacity building. Current work at Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health focuses on generating evidence to improve cancer prevention, screening, diagnosis, treatment, patient navigation, and public health policy.

CORE COMPETENCIES

Project design, planning & management	Cancer program leadership	Program development & implementation
Strategic thinking & planning	Monitoring & evaluation	Research & surveillance
Public engagement & campaign management	Advocacy & communication	Coordination & collaboration
Partnership building	Policy development	Budget management

EDUCATION

Master of Public Health (MPH) · 2011–2013

University of Missouri · Columbia, Missouri, U.S.A.

Doctor of Medicine (MD) · 1998–2006

Kandahar University Faculty of Medicine · Kandahar, Afghanistan

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Department Associate Oct 2024–Present

Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health · Boston, U.S.A.

- Conduct research on cancer prevention and control to generate evidence informing healthcare, public health, and policy.
- Analyze data and evaluate cancer prevention and control programs, including screening, diagnosis, and treatment.
- Present findings and assessments to improve cancer screening, diagnosis, treatment, and patient navigation.

Postdoctoral Research Fellow Jul 2022–Jun 2024

Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health · Boston, U.S.A.

- Coordinated cancer research projects with experts and institutions.
- Collected, managed, and analyzed data on cancer prevention and control.
- Developed publications, presentations, and posters and presented findings at seminars and conferences.

Senior Expert, National Cancer Strategy Development May–Aug 2021

Deutsche Gesellschaft für Internationale Zusammenarbeit (GIZ) · Kabul, Afghanistan

- Led the national cancer-control capacity assessment and coordinated working groups and stakeholders.
- Drafted the national strategy and implementation plan and facilitated consensus-building workshops.
- Supported assessment, data analysis, reporting, and strategic planning.

Consultant, National NCDIs Strategy Development Jan–Mar 2021

World Health Organization · Kabul, Afghanistan

- Led development of the National Strategic Plan for Prevention and Control of Non-Communicable Diseases and Injuries (2022–2026).
- Coordinated national stakeholders and technical committees and developed monitoring and evaluation components.
- Supported national data collection, analysis, reporting, and consensus-building.

Head, National Cancer Control Program (NCCP) Dec 2016–Dec 2020

Ministry of Public Health · Kabul, Afghanistan

- Established Afghanistan’s National Cancer Control Program and served as its inaugural leader.
- Launched the first population-based cancer registry, collecting and analyzing more than 10,000 cancer cases.

• Coordinated Afghanistan’s first imPACT Mission and developed the National Cancer Control Strategy and Implementation Plan.

• Led more than 100 national training programs reaching approximately 2,000 healthcare professionals.

• Established oncology departments in Herat and Balkh and built partnerships with WHO, IAEA, IARC, UICC, TATA Memorial Hospital, and others.

• Facilitated inclusion of oncology medicines in the National Licensed Medicines List for the first time.

ADDITIONAL PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Coordinator, Cancer Diagnosis & Treatment Project Mar–Dec 2016

Kabul, Afghanistan

- Developed the project plan and coordinated government, non-government, donor, financial, and technical partners.
- Established the first Cancer Center in Afghanistan and initiated the country's first hospital-based cancer registry.
- Led public awareness, advocacy, procurement, staffing, budgeting, reporting, and implementation activities.

Executive Director (part-time) Jul 2016–Apr 2018

Afghanistan Cancer Foundation · Kabul, Afghanistan

- Co-founded the Afghanistan Cancer Foundation and developed its strategy and implementation plan.
- Built partnerships with government agencies, donors, civil society, diplomatic missions, and international organizations.
- Conducted fundraising activities in Afghanistan and internationally; the CV records more than US$250,000 raised for ACF.
- Led media, advocacy, awareness, grant-writing, and organizational activities.

National Health Promotion Consultant Aug 2014–Mar 2016

EPOS (GOPA) / European Commission · Kabul, Afghanistan

- Planned, implemented, and evaluated health-promotion projects addressing chronic disease prevention and control.
- Developed health-promotion policies, guidelines, monitoring and evaluation plans, and communication materials.
- Established the Healthy City Project and Health Promoting Hospitals project and contributed to national strategic documents.

Principal Investigator Sep 2013–Feb 2014

Afghanistan National Public Health Institute · Kabul, Afghanistan

- Developed research proposals, protocols, project plans, staffing and budgets; supervised field implementation and reporting.

Resident General Surgeon Sep 2007–Dec 2010

Ibn-e-Sina Emergency Hospital, Ministry of Public Health · Kabul, Afghanistan

- Conducted national research on non-operative management of stab abdominal trauma and prepared a clinical protocol.
- Organized medical conferences and developed the hospital website, described in the CV as the first for a public hospital in Afghanistan.

Editorial Manager Jan 2007–Dec 2010

Da Roghtia Deeva Magazine · Kabul, Afghanistan

- Established and managed the quarterly medical/health magazine, coordinating editorial planning, publication, budgeting, and fundraising.

SELECTED LEADERSHIP & SERVICE

- Member, Regional Strategy for Cervical Cancer Elimination, EMRO/WHO (2022).
- Cancer Control Focal Point to WHO (2017–2021) and IAEA (2020).
- Coordinator, Afghanistan imPACT Mission (2017).
- Chair, Disease Control Priorities 3 Working Group (Cancer), Ministry of Public Health (2018–2019).
- Chair, Kabul Cancer Registry Committee, Ministry of Public Health (2018–2020).
- Secretary, Leadership Committee for COVID-19 Prevention and Control (2020).
- Member of national committees on health strategy, mental health, suicide prevention, child/adolescent health, oral health, and health promotion.

PROFESSIONAL SOCIETIES

- American Society of Clinical Oncology (ASCO) · 2017–
- American Public Health Association (APHA) · 2014–
- European Society of Medical Oncology (ESMO) · 2018–
- Union for International Cancer Control (UICC) · 2017–
- International Association of Cancer Registries (IACR) · 2018–
- Delta Omega Honorary Society of Public Health · 2019–
- Fulbright Alumni Association · 2014–
- Afghanistan National Public Health Association · 2013–
- NCD Alliance · 2019–

SELECTED AWARDS & HONORS

- Fulbright — U.S. Department of State (2009).
- Achievement Awards — National Assembly of Afghanistan (2016, 2021).
- Achievement Award — Senate of Afghanistan (2019).
- Achievement Awards — First Lady of Afghanistan (2016, 2018).
- Achievement Award — Afghanistan’s Doctors and Healthcare Workers Association (2018).
- 10 Year Anniversary Alumni Award — University of Missouri Public Health Program (2017).
- Gama Eta Chapter Membership — Delta Omega Honorary Society of Public Health (2019).

Maihan Abdullah

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS

2026 Abdullah M, et al. The descriptive epidemiology of gastric cancer in Afghanistan: a population-based cancer registry, 2018–2020. Gastric Cancer. 29(3):550–560. DOI: 10.1007/s10120-026-01734-x.

2026 Abdullah M, Hashimi I, Bump JB, et al. Cancer care in Afghanistan: A comprehensive analysis of opportunities and challenges in a low-income and conflict-affected country. International Journal of Cancer. Published online March 13, 2026. DOI: 10.1002/ijc.70431.

2025 Abdullah M, et al. Cancer Incidence in Kabul, Afghanistan: The First Report From the Population-Based Cancer Registry. Cancer Medicine. 14(8):e70844. DOI: 10.1002/cam4.70844. PMID: 40249646; PMCID: PMC12007459.

2025 Abdullah M. Cancer care in SAARC countries. The Lancet Oncology. 26(3):e125. DOI: 10.1016/S1470-2045(25)00067-1. PMID: 40049201.

2023 Abdullah M, Essar MY, Noormal AS, Rasikh SB, Head MG, Bump JB. Banning women from public spaces in Afghanistan: the health and economic consequences of the new regulation. Medicine, Conflict and Survival. 2023.

2023 Abdullah M, Hashimi SI, Masoom MK. Estimating the Cancer Treatment Cost for 5 Common Types of Cancer with Separating Out-of-Pocket and Governmental Costs in Afghanistan, 2020. Asian Pacific Journal of Cancer Prevention. 24(4):1103–1104.

2021 Abdullah M, Niazi N, Pakteen M. Palliative Care: The Care That Is Rarely Practiced in Health System of Afghanistan. In: Palliative Care for Chronic Cancer Patients in Community: Global Approaches and Future Perspective. Springer. pp. 447–454.

2020 Shah S, Ahmad R, Frank K, Abdullah M. Demographic Profile of Gastric Cancer in Afghanistan. Indian Journal of Oncology.

2019 Brant JM, et al., including Abdullah M. Global Survey of the Roles, Satisfaction, and Barriers of Home Health Care Nurses on the Provision of Palliative Care. Journal of Palliative Medicine. 22(8):945–960.

SELECTED RESEARCH PROJECTS

• Principal Investigator: Management of Surgical Biopsy in Tertiary Health Care Facilities in Kabul — cross-sectional study of 180 hospitals (2022).

• Principal Investigator: Knowledge, Attitude, and Practices of Surgeons about Pathology Specimen in Kabul (2021).

• Co-Investigator: Quality Evaluation of Afghanistan’s First Population-based Cancer Registry (2020).

• Principal Investigator: Knowledge, Attitude and Behavior of Afghans regarding Malaria, Tuberculosis and HIV/AIDS — national cross-sectional study (2014).

• Co-Investigator: Knowledge, Attitude and Practices of Afghan School Girls about Hygiene and Sanitation — national cross-sectional study (2014).

• Principal Investigator: Non-operative Management of Stab Abdominal Trauma in Afghanistan — quasi-experimental study (2010).

• Principal Investigator: What Afghan Teens Use the Internet for? — cross-sectional study in four regional provinces (2006).

TEACHING & MENTORSHIP

• Cancer Registry — Kabul Cancer Registry (2017–2024).

• Research Methodology — Afghanistan National Public Health Institute (2014–2021).

• Behavior Change Communication — Ministry of Public Health (2014–2020) and Emerging Leaders Consulting Services (2014–2021).

• Cancer Prevention and Control — National Cancer Control Program (2016–2020); Kateb and Cheragh Universities (2017–2021).

• Fulbright Student Mentorship — Afghanistan Fulbright Association (2014–2021).

EDITORIAL ACTIVITIES

• Editorial Board Member, Razi International Medical Journal (2022–).

• Abstract Reviewer, APHA Annual Meeting and Expo (2020–).

• Assistant Editor, Ghazanfar Medical Journal (2014–2016).

• Editorial Board Member, Roghtia Magazine (2014–2016).

• Editorial Manager, De Roghtia Deeva Health Magazine (2007–2010).

• Author, English to Pashto Medical Dictionary (2005–2007).

SELECTED PRESENTATIONS & CONFERENCES

- London Global Cancer Week (2024).
- UICC World Cancer Congress (2024).
- APHA Annual Meeting and Expo (2023).
- IACR Scientific Conference (2021).
- Asian Pacific Organization for Cancer Prevention (2020).
- World Cancer Leaders' Summit (2019).
- 18th International Congress on the Future of Breast Cancer (2019), San Diego, U.S.A.
- Health Literacy and Communication Strategies / National Cancer Policy Forum (2019), Washington, D.C., U.S.A.
- UICC Leadership in Action Workshop (2019), Muscat, Oman.
- World Cancer Congress (2018), Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia.
- World Cancer Leaders' Summit (2018), Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia.
- International Conference on Health Promoting Hospitals and Health Services (2017), Vienna, Austria.
- European Society of Gynecological Oncology Annual Conference (2016), Antalya, Turkey.
- UICC World Cancer Congress (2016), Paris, France.

SELECTED COURSES & TRAINING

- Non-communicable Diseases in Humanitarian Settings — University of Copenhagen (2024).
- Introduction to Breast Cancer — Yale University (2024).
- Large Scale Effectiveness Evaluation — Harvard School of Public Health (2023).
- Introduction to Dissemination and Implementation Science — Harvard School of Public Health (2023).
- Cancer Registry Training Course — International Agency for Research on Cancer (2023).
- Managing Sustainable and Effective Cancer Civil Society Organizations — UICC (2023).
- Cancer Prevention — Harvard School of Public Health (2022).
- High Quality Health System — Harvard School of Public Health (2022).

LANGUAGES

Language	Speak	Read	Write	Listening
Dari / Farsi	Fluent	Fluent	Fluent	Fluent
Pashto	Fluent	Fluent	Fluent	Fluent
English	Fluent	Fluent	Fluent	Fluent
Urdu	Fluent	Fluent	Fluent	Fluent

SELECTED ADVOCACY & VOLUNTEERING

- Advocacy for HPV vaccination and cancer prevention/control in Afghanistan.
- Afghanistan Tobacco Control Law advocacy and public-health policy engagement.
- Indoor Smoke Free Ordinance advocacy in Rolla, Missouri, through the American Cancer Society.
- Medicaid expansion and public-health advocacy in Missouri.
- Volunteer affiliations include Afghanistan NCD Alliance, Afghanistan Cancer Foundation, Afghan Women's Support Forum, Afghanistan Fulbright Association, Afghanistan National Public Health Association, Afghanistan Dental Relief Project, American Cancer Society, Meals on Wheels, Dance Marathon, and United Way.

SELECTED MEDIA & PROFESSIONAL RESOURCES

- Establishing Afghanistan's First Cancer Registry.
- Establishing HPH Project in Afghanistan: Challenges and Opportunities.
- Integrated Package of Essential Health Services 2019.
- National Cancer Control Program media and public-awareness resources.
- UICC Leadership in Action and other cancer-control presentations and resources.

This public-facing CV is a condensed version of the source curriculum vitae provided for the academic portfolio. The full CV may be maintained separately for complete publication, committee, media, advocacy, and project records.